The attacks were not confined to the Indian positions along the eastern border, between the NEFA and Tibet; a remote Indian Army outpost in Ladakh's Aksai Chin area in the northeastern corner of the state of Jammu and Kashmir was also attacked. Ten minutes later, Chinese ground forces commenced their attack, and that outpost was overrun. According to Indian military sources, the defenders had no artillery pieces or mortars, only small arms and open trenches to fight from.[3] Not a single Indian soldier at that company outpost escaped alive or unhurt. Of the 68 men defending the position, 36 were killed, and the others were wounded or taken prisoner.

Following this initial success in Ladakh, the Chinese advanced, launching multidirectional attacks from the north, south, and east on other Indian positions in the area. Chinese intelligence gathering in the area prior to the attacks had been meticulous. Having spent several years in Tibet, occupying the country, and preparing for a war against India, the Chinese were also acclimatized to the high altitude, and they were evidently trained in how to make breaches in the half-constructed network of Indian defences.[4]

By the end of October, the Chinese had occupied most of the strategic Kailash Range that rises from the eastern flank of the upper Indus Valley, the strategic Kongka Pass, and the area down to Pangong Lake, an endorheic lake with saline water situated at an altitude of more than 4,000 metres. Four battalions of Indian troops had entirely been wiped out and others were in retreat from their positions in the highlands. Then followed a lull in the fighting while the Chinese reorganized their forces, strengthened their defence lines, and brought in more supplies. On 18 November, they were ready to strike again, and multidirectional attacks were used here as elsewhere on the battlefront to encircle and crush the Indian outposts that remained in the area.

But then, on 19 November, the same day as the PLA reached Bomdila, China's Premier Zhou Enlai called Purnendyu Kumar Banerjee, the Indian chargé d'affaires in Beijing, to his residence. Zhou informed him that, on 21 November, the Chinese would declare a ceasefire and begin to withdraw all their troops to positions 20 kilometres north of the LAC. The Chinese stuck to their pledge, and the war was over. Within a couple of weeks, the PLA was back on the Chinese-controlled side of the mountains.